

App Store screenshots, OG images, and the marketing surface

Week 9, Lecture 1 · Design for Builders: Ship Beautiful Products as a Founder

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- App Store screenshot anatomy: dimensions, layers, and thumbnail legibility
- OG image patterns: 1200×630, safe zones, and what platforms crop
- Favicons across platforms: 16px to 512px and the SVG favicon
- Social-share cards: X, LinkedIn, iMessage, and the one layout that survives all three

Part 1: App Store screenshots

The marketing surface

- Before a user opens your app, they see a different product: the marketing surface
- The App Store listing, link previews, browser tabs, and social feeds are all designed assets
- A weak marketing surface sends users away before they interact with the product
- The App Launchpad (2026): the first screenshot is “the headline of your listing”

Required dimensions: iPhone

- 6.7" iPhone (required primary): 1290 × 2796 px
- 6.5" iPhone (still accepted): 1242 × 2688 px
- 5.5" iPhone (older devices): 1242 × 2208 px
- Produce the 6.7" size only. Apple accepts it for all slots.
- iPad primary: 2048 × 2732 px (12.9"). Separate set if you support iPad.

The three-layer structure

Every screenshot has exactly three layers

- Background: solid fill or gradient in your brand color
 - Device frame: transparent PNG of the phone outline with the app screen inside
 - Text overlay: feature message in large, bold type
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- Remove the device frame
 - Does the text overlay still communicate the value?
 - If no: the text overlay is not doing enough work

The App Launchpad test

Thumbnail legibility

- App Store search results display screenshots at roughly 320px wide
- At 320px: the device frame is a small rectangle
- Any text below 28px in your layout is unreadable at that size
- Feature message: 48–72px minimum, boldest weight of your brand typeface
- One message per screenshot. Not a feature list. One claim.

Screenshot feature hierarchy

- Screenshot 1: primary value proposition ("do your best work")
- Screenshot 2: key differentiating feature ("works offline")
- Screenshot 3: trust signal or social proof ("used by 10,000 teams")
- Screenshots 4–5: supporting features
- The first screenshot must work if the user sees nothing else

Part 2: OG images and social-share cards

What an OG image is

- Preview image that appears when someone pastes a URL into Slack, X, LinkedIn, or iMessage
- Name comes from the Open Graph protocol, which Facebook introduced and every platform now reads
- Two parts: a designed image at the correct dimensions, and a `<meta>` tag in your page head
- If you do not set `og:image`, the platform generates a preview from your page content (usually bad)

The meta tags you need

```
<meta property="og:image" content="https://yourapp.com/og.png" />
<meta property="og:image:width" content="1200" />
<meta property="og:image:height" content="630" />
<meta name="twitter:card" content="summary_large_image" />
<meta name="twitter:image" content="https://yourapp.com/og.png" />
```

- These tags go in your page `<head>`
- One image URL covers all platforms except cases where you want platform-specific messaging
- Verify your tags at opengraph.xyz before shipping

OG image dimensions and safe zone

Dimensions

Richardson (2023) safe zone rule

- Canonical size: 1200 × 630 px (1.91:1)
 - Safe for: LinkedIn, Slack, Discord, X
 - iMessage: crops to square (centered)
 - Keep all critical content in center 60% of the frame
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- 80px margin on every side
 - Product name, tagline, and logo inside the margin
 - Nothing critical flush to the edge
 - Survives every platform crop

Three OG image patterns

- **Brand + tagline.** Logo and tagline on a solid or gradient brand background. Low information density, high legibility. Works for any product.
- **Screenshot preview.** Product screenshot on the right, logo and tagline on the left. Works when the UI is clean. Fails when the screenshot is too small to read.
- **Social proof.** Quote from press or a user in large type, logo small in a corner. Works only if you have a memorable quote.

Social-share cards: platform differences

- X (Twitter): `summary_large_image` card, 1200 × 630 px. Crops to 2:1 if the image is taller.
- LinkedIn: recommended 1200 × 627 px. Virtually identical to OG canonical.
- iMessage: square crop, roughly centered.
- Slack and Discord: respect the full 1.91:1 frame.
- One image at 1200 × 630 px with an 80px safe zone works for all five.

Part 3: favicons

Why favicons need more than one size

- Browser tab: 16 × 16 px (favicon.ico, legacy)
- High-DPI browser tab: 32 × 32 px (favicon-32.png)
- iOS add-to-homescreen: 180 × 180 px (apple-touch-icon.png)
- PWA and Play Store: 512 × 512 px (icon-512.png)
- Modern browsers (Chrome 80+, Firefox 41+): favicon.svg (scales to any size)
- Minimum set for a 2026 web product: all five

The SVG favicon

- Renders crisp at any size without rasterization artifacts
- Supports `prefers-color-scheme`: your favicon auto-switches light/dark
- Start with the SVG, then rasterize it for PNG and ICO exports
- In your HTML `<head>`: `<link rel="icon" type="image/svg+xml" href="/favicon.svg">`
- Followed by: `<link rel="alternate icon" href="/favicon.ico">` (fallback for IE)

The 16px problem

- Fine lines, serifs, and gradients collapse at 16px
- The solution is a separate, simplified artifact: not a scaled-down logo
- What survives 16px: one bold letter, one simple geometric shape, two colors maximum, no shadows
- The 16px version should read as a distinct silhouette, not a blurred detail
- Design the 16px version last, after you know what needs to be simplified

The screenshot that requires zoom-in to read has failed its primary job.

<footer>Seth Richardson, 2023</footer>

Take-aways

1. The marketing surface is the first version of your product most users see. It deserves the same design care as the product screens.
2. App Store screenshots succeed or fail at 320px wide. The text overlay is the message; the device frame is supporting evidence.
3. OG image: 1200 × 630 px, 80px safe zone on every side, critical content in the center 60%.
4. Favicon: five files, the SVG is the most important for modern browsers, the 16px ICO is a separate simplified artifact.
5. One screenshot, one claim. Trying to communicate three features in one screenshot communicates none of them.

What's next

- **Reading:** Week 9 reading covers the full marketing surface plus license literacy for every asset type
- **Lecture 2 (this week):** Asset hunting: fonts, icons, photos, and illustrations from legal free sources
- **Section (this week):** Asset studio. Bring your brand sheet. Leave with all five deliverables built.
- **HW 4 (due this week):** Brand sheet due before section